

Yale University  
**DIGITAL ANTHROPOLOGY**

ANTH 411 Spring 2019

Syllabus

Professor Eve Zucker

Eve.Zucker@yale.edu

**Course Meetings:**

Thursdays: 9:25 – 11:15

Room: WTS A46

**Office Hours:**

Wed, 11:15-12:00pm, 1:30-2:00;

Thur, 11:15-12:15 (or by apt.)

Office: Dept. of Anthropology

10 Sachem Street, Room 121

**Course Overview**

Digital Anthropology is an emerging field of anthropology that explores the ways in which digital mediums such as internet platforms are shaping and being shaped by human experience. This advanced seminar course is designed to be a collaborative exploration of the ways in which digital mediums, practices and technologies have become part of the human experience. The seminar approaches the topic from an anthropological perspective drawing on relevant ethnographies as well as cross-disciplinary texts and media to explore this emergent topic. Topics include (but are not limited to) historical background, theory and ethnography, social media, online gaming, and more.

**Requirements**

**Presentation:** You are responsible for giving a short presentation (15 minutes) and lead the seminar discussion for a particular week. The presentation should briefly summarize the work and include a discussion of how the readings fit with each other and other readings in the course when applicable. In addition, the presenter should prepare 5-8 questions for class discussion. The presentation should be submitted in written form to me. The presentation days will be assigned on the first day of class.

**Response Essays:** You are asked to provide 2 short (2-3-page, double-spaced) response essays discussing the readings for that week that highlights and briefly discusses the main arguments and your response. Critical analysis rather than summation is preferred and questions the readings raise should be included and can be raised during class discussion. The **first response essay** is to be submitted on the week of your choice **between weeks 2-7**, providing the response corresponds to the topic of the day and that it is not on the same week of your presentation. The **second response essay** must be given between **weeks 8-12**, again not on the same day you are presenting.

**Final Paper and Presentation:** Graduate students are required to write a final paper 15-16 pages in length double spaced (approximately 4,000 words). Undergraduates are required to write a 10-12 page paper (about 3,000 words). The paper should focus on a topic or theme raised in the seminar and should draw include several of the readings from the class but can also include additional sources.

Graduate students will also be required to give a 5-10-minute presentation of their final paper project on the last day of class. For undergraduates the presentation is optional.

All students are required to submit your paper topic for approval by week 7. The paper topic should be submitted in writing with a brief synopsis of about 500 words and include a preliminary bibliography.

**Class Participation:** One of the aims of this course is to develop new insights and understandings through engaged dialogue on the course topics. To reap the maximum benefit of the seminar, it is important that all students contribute by sharing their questions, understandings and insights with one another, by listening to each other, and by engaging in creative and constructive dialogue. Given that the topics of the course can provoke strong sentiments, it is important to remember to be respectful and sensitive toward one-another. It is only through engaged and open dialogue that we can achieve better knowledge and understanding.

### Attendance

Attendance is mandatory and is included as part of your class participation.

### Grading

Grading is based on class participation, response papers, the presentation and its accompanying essay, and a final paper.

| Grading Rubric                                  |     |
|-------------------------------------------------|-----|
| Class Participation (attendance, contributions) | 10% |
| Response Papers (2 @ 10 points each)            | 20% |
| Presentation (verbal and written)               | 30% |
| Final Paper Topic Abstract/bib (due week 7)     | 10% |
| Final Paper (Due one week after final class)    | 30% |

### Statement on Academic Integrity

**A Word About Plagiarism:** You must document all of your source material. If you take any text from somebody else, you must make it clear the text is being quoted and where the text comes from. You must also cite any sources from which you obtain numbers, ideas, or other material. If you have any questions about what does or does not constitute plagiarism, ask! Plagiarism is a serious offense and will not be treated lightly. Please be sure to review Yale's Academic Integrity Policy. You can find a fuller discussion of using sources and avoiding plagiarism on the Writing Center Website

<http://www.yale.edu/yalecollege/freshmen/academics/introduction/honesty.html>

And students should visit the following useful guide to citing sources at:

<http://writing.yalecollege.yale.edu/principles-citing-sources>

If you have questions about citing sources or remain unclear about plagiarism, please feel free to ask me, a reference librarian in any of the Yale libraries, or staff members at the Yale College Writing Center. If you plagiarize you will fail the class.

## Course Materials

All course materials including articles, books and films will be placed on reserve with the exception of materials that can be accessed electronically including book chapters and articles. The electronic sources are accessible through links on the syllabus which you will find posted in Canvas. Films that cannot be accessed through the internet will be available in course reserves. We will try to watch clips from most of the films in class, but you should watch the films on your own in their entirety.

Books to be purchased:

- Miller, Daniel (2011) *Tales from Facebook*, Polity Press, UK.
- Boellstorff, Tom 2008. *Coming of Age in Second Life: An Anthropologist Explores the Virtually Human*. Princeton
- Horst, Heather and Daniel Miller (2012) *Digital Anthropology*, Berg. (Or you can find it [online](#))
- Coleman, Gabriella (2014) *Hacker, Hoaxer, Whistleblower, Spy: The Many Faces of Anonymous*, Verso.

## TOPICS AND READINGS

**Please note the following:**

- Readings should be read and films should be watched before the class they are assigned for unless it is stated otherwise.
- Additional readings or films may be recommended as the course progresses, and some reading may be changed as we go along. Please make sure to check the announcements and syllabus regularly!
- If films are not available, you will not be required to view them. While we hope to watch segments of most of the films in class, depending on availability and time, we may not be able to watch all of them.

## Introduction

### Jan 17 Week 1 Introduction and Course Overview – from the print revolution to the digital

- Anderson, Benedict, 'The Origin of National Consciousness' in *Imagined Communities*, ch. 3, pp. 37-46. (Course Readings)
- Pettitt, Thomas, The Gutenberg Parenthesis (in class)

#### **Additional Recommended Reading**

- Appadurai, Arjun (1997), [Modernity at Large: Cultural Dimensions of Globalization](#), University of Minneapolis Press. (Chapters 1 and 2).

### Jan 24 Week 2 What is Digital Anthropology?

- Horst, Heather and Daniel Miller (2012) [Digital Anthropology](#), Berg. (chapter 1)
- Boellstorff, T. (2012). Rethinking digital anthropology. In H. A. Horst & D. Miller (Eds.), [Digital Anthropology](#) (Chapter 2: pp. 39-60). London: Bloomsbury.

- Coleman, E. (2010). [Ethnographic Approaches to Digital Media](#). Annual Review of Anthropology, 39, 487-505.
- Pertierra, Anna Cristina (2018) *Media Anthropology for the Digital Age*, Cambridge, UK ; Malden, MA Polity Press, 2018. (Chapter 4) – Course Readings

### **Additional Recommended Reading**

- Roger Sanjek and Susan W. Tratner, (eds), *eFieldnotes: The Makings of Anthropology in the Digital World*, University of Pennsylvania Press, 2015.
- Pertierra, Anna Cristina (2018) *Media Anthropology for the Digital Age*, Cambridge, UK; Malden, MA: Polity Press, 2018. (Chapter 7)

### **Jan 31 Week 3 – Mobile Phones (and other devices)**

- Madianou, Mirca and Daniel Miller, *Phone Parenting: Reconfiguring relationships between Filipina migrant mothers and their left-behind children*, New Media & Society Vol 13, Issue 3, pp. 457 – 470, First Published March 23, 2011
- Barendregt, Bart, *Diverse Digital Worlds*, in “[Digital Anthropology](#)” Horst and Miller (Chapter 10)
- Vue, Pao. [To Catch a Nyus Vais Forest Spirit with a Cellphone](#), 2016.
- Kraemer, Daniela. 2017. “[‘Do You Have a Mobile?’ Mobile Phone Practices and the Refashioning of Social Relationships in Port Vila Town](#).” Australian Journal of Anthropology 28 (1): 39–55. doi:10.1111/taja.12165
- Hahn, Hans Peter, and Ludovic Kibora. “[The Domestication of the Mobile Phone: Oral Society and New ICT in Burkina Faso](#).” The Journal of Modern African Studies 46, no. 1 (2008): 87-109.
- Applin, Sally A. and Fischer, Michael (2011), [A Cultural Perspective on Mixed, Dual and Blended Reality](#), IUI Workshop on Location Awareness for Mixed and Dual Reality, LAMDa’11, 13. February 2011, Palo Alto

### **Additional Recommended Reading**

- Horst, Heather A., and Miller, Daniel. (2006). [The Cell Phone: An Anthropology of Communication](#). London: Bloomsbury Publishing PLC.
- Rafael, Vicente L. 2003. “The Cell Phone and the Crowd: Messianic Politics in the Contemporary Philippines.” Public Culture 15(3): 399–425.
- Humphreys, Lee and Thomas Barker [Modernity and the Mobile Phone: Exploring Tensions about Dating and Sex in Indonesia](#), M/C Journal 10.1 (2007).

### **Feb 7 Week 4 – Sociality and Technology**

- Turkle, Sherry, (2012) [Alone Together: Why We Expect More from Technology and Less from Each Other](#). Basic Books, 2012. (selected chapters)
- Ginsburg, Faye Disability in the Digital Age, In H. A. Horst & D. Miller (Eds.), [Digital Anthropology](#) (Chapter 5: pp. 101-119). London: Bloomsbury.

## Feb 14 - Week 5 – Facebook

- Miller, Daniel (2011) *Tales from Facebook*, Polity Press, UK. (Selected Chapters)
- Miller, Daniel. (2017) [The ideology of friendship in the era of Facebook](#), HAU: Journal of Ethnographic Theory 7, no. 1 (Spring 2017): 377-395

### ***Additional Suggested Reading***

- Zuckerberg, Mark (2017) [Building Global Community](#), 16, February, 2017.
- Boellstorff, Tom (2017) [Zuckerberg and the Anthropologist: Facebook, Culture, Digital Futures](#), February 27, 2017.

## Feb 21 Week 6 –The Dark Side of Social Media (Part I)

- Coleman, Gabriella (2014) *Hacker, Hoaxer, Whistleblower, Spy: The Many Faces of Anonymous*, Verso. (Introduction, Chapters 1, 3, 5, 11)
- Film: The Cleaners

### ***Additional Suggested Reading***

- Phillips, Whitney. (2015). [This is why we can't have nice things : mapping the relationship between online trolling and mainstream culture](#).

## Feb 28 Week 7 – The Dark Side of Social Media (Part II)

(Special Guest: Prof. Jonathan Ong, University of Amherst)

- [How Facebook's Rise Fueled Chaos and Confusion in Myanmar](#), Wired Magazine. By Timothy McLaughlin, July 6, 2016
- Lim, Merlyna (2017) Freedom to hate: social media, algorithmic enclaves, and the rise of tribal nationalism in Indonesia, *Critical Asian Studies*, 49:3, 411-427 (course readings)
- Ong, Jonathan and Jason Cabañes. Architects of Networked Disinformation: Behind the Scenes of Troll Accounts and Fake News Production in the Philippines (course readings)

### ***Additional Suggested Reading***

- What's App – India <https://www.dw.com/en/india-google-engineer-latest-victim-of-mob-lynchings-fueled-by-whatsapp-rumors/a-44679902>
- Social Media – Sri Lanka - [Sri Lanka blocks social media as deadly violence continues](#)
- Aug 16 -[Facebook losing the war on Myanmar hate speech](#), Reuters.

**PAPER TOPIC WITH ABSTRACT AND BIBLIOGRAPHY DUE**

### Mar 7 Week 8: Politics and Nationalism in Cyberspace

- Bernal, Victoria, (2014), *Nation as Network: Diaspora, Cyberspace, and Citizenship*, University of Chicago Press (Introduction, Chapter 5) -
- Yongming, Zhou (2006) [Informed Nationalism: military websites in Chinese cyberspace](#), Journal of Contemporary China, Volume 14, 2005 - Issue 44
- Lim, M. (2017) Digital Media and Malaysia's Electoral Reform Movement. In *Citizenship and Democratization in Southeast Asia* (eds. W. Berenschot, H. Schulte Nordholt, & L. Bakker), Leiden: Brill, 211-237. (Course Readings)
- Postill, J. and L.C. Epafra (2017) [Tweeting religion in Indonesia: when political arenas go viral](#). American Ethnologist (virtual issue)

**Week 9 - NO CLASS SPRING BREAK**

**Week 10 - NO CLASS SPRING BREAK**

### Mar 28 Week 11 - - Virtual Worlds and Gaming

- Boellstorff, Tom 2008. *Coming of Age in Second Life: An Anthropologist Explores the Virtually Human*. Princeton (selected chapters)
- Malaby, Thomas M. 2012 *Digital Gaming, Game Design and Its Precursors*, in "[Digital Anthropology](#)" Horst and Miller (Chapter 14)
- **Film:** *Gamer Revolution (If Available)*

#### **Recommended Additional Reading**

- [Fearless heroes needed for Cambodia's first console game](#), Phnom Penh Post, [Rinith Taing](#) | Publication date 06 March 2018

### Apr 4 Week 12 – Virtual Worlds and Gaming Cont. and Art and Creativity

- Yee, Nick (2014) [The Proteus Paradox : How Online Games and Virtual Worlds Change Us-and How They Don't](#), Yale University Press. (selected chapters)
- Wilf, Eitan 2013 [Toward an Anthropology of Computer-Mediated, Algorithmic Forms of Sociality](#). *Current Anthropology* 54(6): 716–739.
- Refik Anadol's Archive Dreaming – In class

### Apr 11 Week 13 – Death and Memorialization

- Kirk, David and Wendy Moncur (2014) *An Emergent Framework for Digital Memorials, Conference on Designing Interactive Systems*, Vancouver, BC (course readings)
- Ryan, Jennie. (2012). [The Digital Graveyard: Online Social Networking Sites as Vehicles of Remembrance, in Human No More](#) : Digital Subjectivities, Unhuman Subjects, and the End of Anthropology, eds. Neil Whitehead and Michael Wesch.

- Heathcote, Anthony (2016) [\*An Image of a Child's Bedroom.\*](#), 2016
- Margaret Gibson (2017) Grievable lives: avatars, memorials, and family 'plots' in Second Life, *Mortality*, 22:3, 224-239 (Course Readings)
- Uimonen, Paula. [\*Mourning Mandela: Sacred Drama and Digital Visuality in Cape Town.\*](#) *Journal of AESTHETICS & CULTURE* 7, no. 1 (2015): 28178. doi:10.3402/JAC.V7.28178. (Course Reserves)
- Acker, Amelia, AND Brubaker, Jed. Death, [\*Memorialization, and Social Media: A Platform Perspective for Personal Archives\*](#) *Archivaria* [Online], Volume 77(23 May 2014)

#### **Additional Recommended Reading**

- Parker, Laura (2014) [\*How to Become Virtually Immortal\*](#), *The New Yorker*, April 4, 2014.

#### **Apr 18 Week 14: - Collective Memory, Memorialization and Digital Archives**

- Hamilton, Annette, [\*Fragments in the Archive: the Khmer Rouge Years\*](#), *Plaridel*, Vol 15, No. 1, pp. 1-14.
- Danilova, Nataliya, [\*The politics of mourning: The virtual memorialisation of British fatalities in Iraq and Afghanistan\*](#), *Memory Studies*, Vol 8, Issue 3, pp. 267 – 281, First Published December 30, 2014
- Hoskins, Andrew, [\*7/7 and connective memory: Interactional trajectories of remembering in post-scarcity\*](#), *Culture, Memory Studies*, 4(3) 269–280, 2011
- Kirkegaard Ane Marie ,Ørbø [\*Recapturing the Lost: Digitalized Memories of the Rhodesian Bush War\*](#), *Society and Conflict*
- Zalewska, Maria, [\*Holography, Historical Indexicality and the Holocaust\*](#), *The Spectator* ; Los Angeles Vol. 36, Iss. 1, (Spring 2016): 25-32.
- Frosh, P. (2018). [\*The mouse, the screen and the Holocaust witness: Interface aesthetics and moral response\*](#). *New Media & Society*, 20(1), 351–368.
- Pardo, Davina, [\*116 Cameras\*](#), (video) *New York Times*, Sept. 19, 2017
- Class activity *Let Them Speak*

#### **Additional Recommended Reading**

- Wootson, Cleve (2017 ) [\*Who betrayed Anne Frank? Artificial intelligence could finally solve the mystery\*](#), *Washington Post*.

#### **Apr 25 Week 15 – Course Wrap Up and Student Paper Presentations**

**Final Paper Due May 2, 2019!!**